sharpened when France, along with Britain and Israel, invaded Egypt in November 1956. With Charles de Gaulle's advent to power in France in 1958, French foreign policy perceptions began to change. The new independent French foreign policy of rejecting bloc politics while seeking an East-West detente seemed to have elements in common with the policy of non-alignment followed by India. By this time, India's problems with France over the French pockets had been amicably settled. The official visit of Prime Minister Georges Pompidou to India in February 1965, the first ever by a French prime minister, was an indication of the increasingly similar attitudes of the two countries on various international issues. Some differences resurfaced during the Soviet occupation of Afghanistan when France, following the US policy, believed that Pakistan needed to be strengthened to counter the Soviet might; nevertheless, Indira Gandhi visited France from 12-15 November 1981, which was considered an important landmark in Indo-French relations. Gandhi held discussions with President Francois Mitterrand and the two countries decided to strengthen their ties in various sectors. The relationship in the trade sector was strengthened by early 1982 with the decision of the Indian government to purchase the highly sophisticated Mirage 2000, for which the French government made credits available on short terms. This agreement, called 'intention to proceed,' was expected to secure India's air defence against Pakistan's acquisition of F-16 aircraft from the USA.

Later in December 1984, Bhardwaj began his day in office reading reports filed by Jindal from Paris as well as a few memos and observation reports from London. Sandhu, he realised, had vanished and then reappeared in the last couple of months. No one really knew where he had been but one of Jindal's reports, probably based on Clarke's input, had suggested